CHAPTER 7

Relentless: The Network Is Always On

Humans are used to being monitored. For millions of years, we have been watched and tracked by other animals, as well as by other humans. Family members, friends and neighbours have always wanted to know what we do and feel, and we have always cared deeply how they see us and what they know about us. Social hierarchies, political manoeuvres and romantic relationships involve a never-ending effort to decipher what other people feel and think and occasionally to hide our own feelings and thoughts.

When centralised bureaucratic networks appeared and developed, one of the bureaucrats' most important roles was to monitor entire populations. Officials in the Qin Empire wanted to know whether we were paying our taxes or plotting resistance. The Catholic Church wanted to know whether we paid our tithes and whether we masturbated. The Coca-Cola Company wanted to know how to persuade us to buy its products. Rulers, priests and merchants wanted to know our secrets in order to control and manipulate us.

Of course, surveillance has also been essential for providing beneficial services. Empires, churches and corporations needed information in order to provide people with security, support and essential goods. In modern states sanitation officials want to know where we get our water from and where we defecate. Health-care officials want to know what illnesses we suffer from and how much we eat. Welfare officials want to know whether we are unemployed or perhaps abused by our spouses. Without this information, they cannot help us.